Subverting the Tracks: Refugee Agency and the 1943 Feldkirch Freight Train Escape



Photograph of platform at Feldkirch Bahnhof, 22 May 2026. Author's personal collection.

The European rail network played a vital role in the "Final Solution," set out against European Jews by the Nazis. Using both freight and passenger cars, the Germans transported millions of people to killing centers in German-occupied Poland and Soviet Union. Many oral histories from Holocaust survivors describe the conditions on the trains as not being provided with food or

water, intense temperatures depending on the season, and the lack of sanitary conditions (United States Holocaust Memorial Museum “German Railways and the Holocaust”). Although it is true that the railway was crucial for the Nazis’ plan and it is vital to educate on the horrors of the “Final Solution,” in general, Holocaust education has conditioned the public to view train cars as purely vehicles of victimhood. By looking at an incident in Feldkirch, Austria a narrative of subversion and resistance, where refugees attempted to reclaim control over the tracks to fight for their survival, is uncovered. Additionally, through this example, Holocaust education may begin to shift from a German-centric viewpoint and allow unheard narratives to be heard.



Photograph of Feldkirch Bahnhof looking east, 29 May 2026. Andrew Chang’s personal collection.

Due to an increase of asylum requests from German Jews, in 1938 Switzerland initiated negotiations with Nazi Germany in hopes of finding a way to limit the number of Jewish

refugees entering their country (St. Louis Kaplan Feldman Holocaust Museum). Fueled by antisemitism, on October 5th, 1938, the Reich Ministry of the Interior invalidated all German passports held by Jews. The German government began requiring Jewish people to identify themselves in a way that would separate them from the rest of the population. All German Jews were now legally required to carry identity cards, their passports were stamped with a red letter "J," and Jews with first names of "non-Jewish" origin had to add "Israel" and "Sara" (United States Holocaust Memorial Museum "German Jews' Passports Declared Invalid"). This act further increased the intense surveillance network that Jews were actively resisting, causing refugees to have to find other avenues of escape.



Photograph of Feldkirch's End of Built-Up Area Sign, 1 June 2026. Author's personal collection.

An example of this escape avenue due to the increased surveillance at the borders happened on January 7th, 1943, in Feldkirch, a small town on the Swiss border. Fourteen Jewish refugees were taken off a coal train after officials became suspicious when wagon SZ 17068 was overloaded, and the sliding door was unable to be opened. The main customs assistant, Reithmeyer, noted at the main customs office that the refugees "covered their faces with scarves to protect them from the frost and cold" and were wearing many layers of clothes. He further noted that they resisted but were eventually forced to crawl out from beneath the coal at gunpoint. After being questioned in detail, Reithmeyer states that the refugees explained they "boarded the wagons in Slovakia on 30 December 1942 in order to avoid being deported to a labor camp" (Loewy). This incident, among others like an escape organization in Medzilaborce that aided in Jews escaping to Switzerland, at the border crossing between Austria and Switzerland gives a primary example of the Jewish resistance within the railway system. By focusing on a lesser-known town in Austria, compared to major cities that are often the focus in Holocaust education, this allows for an expanded understanding of the Holocaust and the other cities and countries involved.



Photograph from Stadtschrofen viewpoint overlooking Feldkirch, 1 June 2026. Author's personal collection.

Acts of resistance that occurred at small border towns are often completely unheard of in most classrooms. By not including these histories, important examples of Jewish resourcefulness and agency are erased. It is essential that Holocaust education shatters the passive-victim stereotype by proving that the German railways were also a space of Jewish agency and attempted global escape. There has been a call for teachers to educate students on Jewish resistance during the Holocaust by using real memoirs and events that focus on various forms of resistance. One teacher at a Jewish Day Schools stressed "the importance and prevalence of different forms of

resistance during the Holocaust" while others claim they "do not want students to leave their classrooms with an impression that Jews went 'like sheep to the slaughter'" (Ellison). Looking at lesser-known histories, like the events in Feldkirch, sheds light onto the often-forgotten physical forms of resistance. Doing so shows that the Holocaust was more than a German historical series of events while also emphasizing the importance of sharing marginalized voices and experiences.

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